

EASTERN SPARKS (BOOK 2)

Chapter 6: Evidence

Luca Voss · Bangkok, Thailand — Yaowarat Road / Chinatown / Chao Phraya

Arno's message came in during breakdown, while Luca was polishing the last of the stemware under the side-station light.

Chinatown after service. Yaowarat. No excuses.

Then, before Luca could answer:

I'm collecting people from two good houses and one impossible Frenchman. You need better street food education. Midnight. I'll send the pin.

Luca looked at the screen, then at the rows of glasses catching the corridor light in clean vertical lines. He knew Arno by reputation before he knew him in person — French-trained, Bangkok-fixed, one of those floor people who seemed to know everyone worth knowing within four square kilometers of any serious dining district. They had met briefly the week before when Arno came through Nusara after his own service with two cooks and a woman from beverage. He'd spoken to Luca for three minutes, asked where he was from, where he'd worked in Tokyo, whether Bangkok had started teaching him yet, and then said, with no particular buildup, *You look like someone who takes notes instead of eating. That's a solvable problem.*

It had apparently been an actual diagnosis.

Luca typed: **What time exactly?**

Arno answered at once.

11:50 if you want the first stall before the line gets stupid. And don't say you're tired. Everyone is tired.

Luca almost smiled. He sent back a thumbs-up and put the phone facedown beside the polishing cloth.

Khun Nok passed the station, saw his expression, and said, "Good news?"

"Apparently I'm being educated," he said.

"Good," she said. "You need it."

Then she walked on, warm and absolute as ever, leaving him with the clean glasses and the feeling that Bangkok had once again arranged something around him before bothering to ask whether he preferred structure.

He finished closing. Went home. Showered quickly enough that the bathroom mirror barely had time to fog. Changed into the least restaurant-looking clothes he owned — dark T-shirt, clean linen overshirt, the worn black trousers that still passed for intentional in most cities. He considered bringing the notebook and did not. Then, after standing in his apartment for four seconds with the door key in his hand, he went back for it anyway.

Not because he intended to write.

Because Bangkok after midnight kept producing things that deserved evidence.

Yaowarat Road at quarter past midnight looked like a city condensed to one bright, sweating artery.

The neon was not decorative. It was functional and relentless — red, gold, green Chinese characters stacked vertically over shopfronts and pharmacies and seafood houses, the signs layered so densely they seemed to hold the street up by color alone. Woks threw up bursts of flame. Oil snapped in shallow pans. Steam rolled from metal carts and vanished into the humid air that was already carrying five other smells at once: char, garlic, pepper, diesel, sugar, star anise, old concrete still releasing the day's heat.

Crowds moved in both directions with the compact forward pressure of people who had come to eat something specific and knew delay was part of the price. Plastic stools in blue and red and the faded orange of long sun exposure sat in clusters on the pavement. Entire meals seemed to materialize and disappear in the width of a breath. Luca stopped at the corner Arno had pinned and let the street hit him whole for a second.

This, he thought, was not a food district. It was a service rush turned inside out and stretched for half a kilometer.

Arno appeared from the crowd carrying two sweating bottles of water by their necks.

"You're punctual," he said, handing one over. "Disturbing habit. Keep it away from the rest of us."

"You're early," Luca said.

"I'm saving you from yourself. Come on."

The group assembled in pieces. A pastry chef from a hotel off Sathorn. A Thai sommelier Luca had seen once at Nusara on her night off. The impossible Frenchman, who turned out to be perfectly possible and only impossible in the sense that he had staged at too many places and spoke about all of them in the same sentence. Two line cooks. A beverage rep. Arno moved through them all with the casual authority of a man who had already decided everyone would have a good time and considered resistance inefficient.

"One more coming," he said, checking his phone. "Actually, no — already here. There."

He lifted his chin toward the edge of the crowd.

Luca followed the gesture without particular expectation.

He heard the laugh before he found the face.

It arrived bright through the traffic noise and the metal clatter and the calls from the seafood stalls — warm, quick, unmistakably amused, carrying a soft Portuguese shape around the edges of the English words that followed it. Not loud. Just exact. The kind of laugh that cut through chaos because it was genuinely itself.

His hand closed around the water bottle hard enough for the plastic to crease.

La Boqueria.

Not the sight of her. The sound. Two stalls down, saffron in her hand maybe, or not saffron, maybe citrus, maybe nothing he'd remembered correctly except the laugh itself — a bright sound in market noise, the one detail that had stayed when the face had not. He had turned then and found only crowd.

He turned now.

She was twenty feet away, stepping off the curb between a dessert cart and a seafood grill, one hand pushing a loose strand of dark hair behind her ear as she answered something Arno had apparently just texted. He knew her at once and not at all.

Not because he had seen her clearly before. Because recognition had a structure of its own. The laugh first. Then the notebook-shaped confidence in the way she moved through a crowd, as if she trusted herself to reach the gap before it closed. Then the face — not familiar in the normal sense, but right, in the way a long-unresolved chord is right when it finally lands.

Arno raised a hand. "Sofia. Finally."

She looked up. Crossed the remaining distance with the measured quickness of someone accustomed to arriving on time by a margin of seconds, not minutes.

"I was here," she said. "You were standing in the middle of the path like a problem."

"Rude," Arno said, kissing the air beside her cheek. Then, with theatrical impatience: "Good. Everyone's here. Luca, Sofia. Sofia, Luca. I am tired of hearing good things about both of you in separate rooms. Sit down somewhere and justify the administrative effort."

The line landed lightly because he said it lightly, already turning to herd the others toward the first stall. But Luca felt the sentence click into place with unnerving ease. Of course. The incredible server mentioned in London. The excellent recommendation at Tokyo's edge. Arno's way of moving people around like furniture until the room made sense. Not fate exactly. Something more irritating and practical.

Sofia looked at him. Not long. Long enough.

He saw the moment she noticed his hands because her eyes dropped there first — the water bottle in one, the other loose at his side, fingers still carrying the slight flex of long service. Not staring. Reading. The same way he would have read a server at the entrance of a dining room: shoes, shoulders, hands, tray arm if visible. Her gaze came back to his face with a tiny change in it, not recognition exactly but professional registration.

"We've passed each other before," she said.

It wasn't a question.

Luca let out a breath that might have been a laugh. "I think we've been failing to meet for almost two years."

Her mouth shifted — not fully a smile yet, but something close enough that he felt it unexpectedly low in his ribs.

"That sounds inefficient," she said.

"Completely," he said.

Arno, already halfway to the corner stall, pointed at them both without turning around. "Less flirting with destiny, more noodles. Move."

Neither of them argued.

The first stop was not where they stayed.

It was a stand-up oyster omelet counter wedged between a gold shop and a pharmacy, all heat and speed and elbows, the cook flipping the egg mixture in a shallow vat of oil with the kind of precision that only looked chaotic if you didn't understand repetition. Arno ordered for half the group without consulting them, which no one seemed to resent because he was correct. Luca stood beside Sofia at the steel ledge while bowls and plates appeared and disappeared and the crowd compressed them by inches at a time.

He was aware of her in pieces first, because that was how crowded places forced perception to work. The clean citrus-and-soap scent left over from someone who had already showered off service. The slight mark at the base of one thumb where a tray edge or a knife spine or years of carrying something precisely had built a callus. The way she shifted left automatically when a server squeezed behind them with a stockpot, making space before the apology was fully spoken.

Server, he thought, unnecessary thought now. Obviously.

"Arno said Nusara stole you from Tokyo," she said over the street noise.

"I prefer to think I was sensibly redirected."

"That's a very Luca answer."

He turned to her. "You've known me thirty seconds."

"I've known your glass-polishing posture for thirty seconds. That's enough for a preliminary report."

That drew an actual laugh out of him — brief, surprised. She heard it and glanced sideways as if she'd been checking a theory.

"And you?" he said. "Arno said you're near Lumpini. French technique, Thai soul."

"That's the brochure version," she said. "The real version is that the duck sauce can break if the station gets nervous and half the room wants to order slowly because the weather makes everyone feel philosophical."

"That sounds more useful."

"It usually is."

Arno called the group onward before either of them could build momentum. Chinatown worked that way: one thing excellent, then movement, then another thing excellent before comparison could begin. They ate grilled squid from skewers under a red sign humming with bad electricity. Peppery pork satay from a cart where the woman working the coals never once looked flustered despite serving thirty people at once. A broth Luca could have spent an hour trying to identify and would still have been wrong about. The group widened and narrowed as people bought drinks and peeled off and rejoined. Bangkok after midnight arranged conversation in fragments.

What it did not arrange, apparently, was distance.

By the time Arno steered them toward a narrower side stretch off Yaowarat proper — a pavement setup under a patched tarp, six aluminum tables, plastic stools, boat noodles moving out of a stockpot in a continuous dark shimmer — Luca and Sofia had ended up next to each other often enough that it no longer read as coincidence.

"Here," Arno said. "This one. Sit where you can. No one gets dignity, only noodles."

Seats were scarce enough to become immediate fact. The sommelier took one end of a table. One cook dragged a stool from somewhere impossible. Someone else gave up and stood. Arno, with the cheerful tyranny of a man who enjoyed logistics, took Luca by the shoulder, turned him half a step, pointed to two empty red stools opposite each other at the last free corner of the pavement table, and said, "Perfect. You two can finally stop doing orbit work and have a conversation." He vanished before either could refuse.

Luca looked at the stools. Then at Sofia.

She gave the smallest shrug. "He's not wrong about the orbit work."

"No," Luca said. "He isn't."

They sat.

The stools were too low, the table slightly sticky despite having been wiped, the traffic close enough to raise the occasional gust of hot exhaust across their ankles. It was perfect.

A woman with silver at both temples set down two small bowls without asking what spice level they wanted. Arno must have ordered already. The broth was dark, almost black in the streetlight, with chopped herbs floating on top and thin slices of beef just turning in the heat.

Sofia looked at the bowl, then at the woman, then back at the bowl again with an expression Luca knew intimately: professional respect at first sight.

"That stockpot has solved problems none of us have earned yet," she said.

"Agreed," he said.

They tasted.

The broth hit deep first — iron-rich, peppered, sweet at the very back, herbs lifting it before it became heavy. Heat gathering without shouting. Time inside the liquid, obvious and unperformed.

Sofia closed her eyes for half a second. Not for drama. For accuracy.

"Keiko sent me here by voice message," she said. "From Tokyo. She said don't skip the pork blood, which I found persuasive because she made it sound like a dare and a love language at the same time."

"That sounds exactly like her," Luca said.

Now she looked up sharply. "You know Keiko?"

"Briefly. Through Sézanne and a beverage class. She terrifies half the room and improves the other half."

Sofia smiled fully then, the first uncomplicated smile, and there it was again — the structure of the laugh inside it, the warmth that had cut through La Boqueria before he ever had a face to put beside it.

"Yes," she said. "That is exactly Keiko."

Something settled.

Not awkwardness easing. Something older than that. The removal of a thin layer of strangeness the evening had been wearing up to now. They had both, he realized, been waiting for a credential that wasn't a restaurant name. Keiko served. So did the bowl between them. So did the fact that she had tasted with her eyes closed for accuracy, not effect.

Around them the table grew loud and then louder. Arno argued with the impossible Frenchman about whether an oyster omelet counted as technique or instinct. One of the line cooks was already ordering another round from the woman with the stockpot by pointing with a chopstick and holding up two fingers. Bangkok kept moving.

At their corner of the table, time changed pace.

The first hour took the easy material.

Where they'd been. What Tokyo had taught them that Europe hadn't. Which rooms had remade them and which merely impressed them. Luca told her about Sézanne's severity and its strange tenderness beneath the severity, about Matsuda-san's rule that confirmation was not complete until you saw the guest receive what you thought you had sent. She nodded before he finished the sentence.

"Yes," she said. "Exactly. People think service is what you say. It isn't. It's whether the other person actually arrives where you meant them to arrive."

"You wrote that down somewhere, didn't you?"

Her eyebrows lifted. "Maybe."

"I knew it."

"You brought your notebook, didn't you?"

He stopped.

She laughed at his face, softer this time. "Your left pocket prints rectangular. Also you touched it twice before sitting down."

"That is invasive," he said.

"That is awareness," she said.

He had no defense against that because she was right.

They moved from Tokyo to Bangkok. From Khun Nok's *faster for this table* to Khun Fon's *keep it honest*. He said the lines. She repeated them once, testing their weight in her own voice. They discovered, with the speed that sometimes happens only between professionals in the same exact trade, that the phrases were describing the same principle from different sides.

"The room tells you its temperature," Sofia said, resting her chopsticks across the bowl. "Bangkok just does it louder."

"And if you impose the wrong pace on it," Luca said, "you start solving your own need for control instead of the table's need."

She pointed at him with the chopsticks. "Yes. That."

It should have felt too fast, how quickly the conversation found its depth. It didn't. It felt efficient in the best possible sense — two people skipping the unnecessary scripts because the subject matter itself was already the credential.

The second hour found the worse stories.

Not in performance. Neither of them had any interest in war-story inflation, the boring competition of who had suffered most beautifully on a floor. But certain terrible shifts are not entertaining until long after they're over, and by then they become a kind of trade inheritance.

He told her about a Saturday in Paris when a private room guest had decided the delay on a course was a moral failure rather than a kitchen error and had made a nineteen-year-old commis cry in the corridor. Sofia told him about a Barcelona lunch where a twelve-top staggered the entire section because the host kept inviting extra people mid-service and announcing each addition like a surprise gift to the room. He described London rain tracked across polished floors and the split second where three stems on a loaded tray had started to tilt and the body solved the geometry before the mind caught up. She described a Ginza guest who spoke only through pauses and how terrifying it was the first time she understood that silence could be either satisfaction or disappointment and there was no external clue except the angle of his shoulders.

They weren't trying to impress each other. That was what made it intimate.

She listened like a server: not jumping ahead, not rushing to fill the beat between his sentences, giving each story exactly enough room to become what it was actually about. He found himself giving her the details that usually got edited out when speaking to people outside the work — the timing, the glassware, the reason a tray matters more when you are tired because fatigue is when technique stops being style and becomes mercy.

At some point the impossible Frenchman and the pastry chef left. Arno shouted goodbye from half a block away, already moving the remainder of the group toward dessert. Luca waved without standing. Sofia raised her hand in acknowledgment but didn't shift her stool.

Neither of them suggested leaving.

The woman with silver at her temples brought another round of noodles to their corner without being asked. Perhaps Arno had told her. Perhaps Bangkok had.

The third hour was where the conversation turned.

There is a point, on certain nights, where professionals stop discussing the work and begin discussing the reason the work got under their skin deeply enough to reorganize a life. The shift is usually visible before it is audible. Posture changes. Pace slows. A person stops curating for competence and starts answering as if accuracy matters more than self-protection.

Sofia asked it first, but not directly.

"What's the shift you still think about when you don't want to?" she said.

Luca looked down at the broth, now reduced to a dark ring around the bowl's edge.

There were several. The bad ones had quantity. The real answer was singular.

"Paris," he said. "Le Gabriel. Winter. Older man dining alone." He paused, not for effect but to retrieve it cleanly. "He wasn't difficult. Quiet. The kind of guest people can accidentally neglect because he never asked for anything twice. On the fourth course he stopped eating for maybe twenty seconds. Just held the spoon. Not upset. Somewhere else."

She didn't interrupt.

"I asked if everything was all right. He said yes. I nearly left it there because technically that answered the question. But his hand didn't move back to the bowl. So I stayed for half a second longer and asked if the dish was taking him somewhere.

"He looked at me as if I'd opened a door he hadn't expected anyone to see. Then he said the broth tasted like what his mother used to make on Sundays after church. She'd been dead seven years. He started crying while apologizing for crying, which is the worst kind because it means the guest is trying to protect you from their own feeling." Luca exhaled once through his nose. "So I told him he never had to apologize for remembering someone at dinner. I brought him ten minutes before the next course. Slowed the room around him without making him aware I'd done it. Afterward he thanked me for not rescuing him too fast."

Sofia's expression had gone very still.

"That's the whole job," she said quietly.

"I know," he said. "I just didn't know it that clearly until then."

She turned the empty bowl a few degrees with one fingertip, thinking.

"In Florence," she said, "I had a woman at lunch who ordered a dessert because her husband wanted one and she didn't. She told me that much with her face before she told me anything with words. Then she took one bite and just—" Sofia touched two fingers briefly under one eye. "Not dramatic. It was almost worse because she was trying not to let it happen. I thought I'd done something wrong. I knelt beside her and she said no, no, it's beautiful, it's just the orange blossom. Her avó used to make a semolina cake with orange blossom water every Easter. She hadn't tasted it in ten years."

Luca watched her while she said avó. The word sat differently in her mouth than the surrounding English, held with a care that made translation impossible and unnecessary.

"What did you do?" he asked.

"Exactly not too much," Sofia said. "I brought coffee and water. Delayed clearing the plate. Told the kitchen privately, because they should know when they hit something real. Let her husband be the one who touched her arm. She came to the pass before leaving and asked if she could thank pastry. She said she hadn't expected lunch to give something back."

The traffic on the street kept flowing. A motorbike buzzed past. Someone two tables over laughed loud and reckless over a plate of crab claws. The city did not hush itself for this. Luca loved it a little for that.

"That's why, then," he said.

She met his eyes. "Why what?"

"Why we keep doing it even when the hours are stupid and your feet feel personally betrayed and someone always, in every city, believes the floor exists to absorb whatever version of themselves they're least proud of that day."

Her mouth moved, the almost-smile again, but there was no lightness in it now. Only recognition.

"Yes," she said. "Because sometimes a dish gives someone their dead mother back for thirty seconds. Or their avó. Or a version of themselves they forgot they missed. And if you're very good, you don't stand in the way of that."

There it was.

Not romance, not exactly, though something in him recognized the danger and beauty of the terrain immediately. Something more foundational. The experience of being fully understood in the exact chamber of the self one had built around the work.

He realized, with mild astonishment, that he was no longer filtering his answers for how they would sound.

"I used to think the goal was mastery," he said. "Make no mistakes. Build the perfect system. Anticipate everything."

"And now?"

"Now I think systems are only useful if they free you to notice people." He glanced at the traffic, the stall, the woman carrying bowls from the stockpot in both hands with a path-width intuition no spreadsheet could teach. "Otherwise you're just building elegant machinery around emptiness."

Sofia sat back a fraction, studying him with that same precise attentiveness she'd first directed at his hands.

"That's a dangerous sentence," she said.

"Why?"

"Because if you keep thinking like that, eventually you'll have to build something with it."

He laughed, low and brief, and she did too.

"What about you?" he asked. "Why do you do this, really? Not the interview answer."

She was quiet long enough that he thought she might refuse. Then she looked down the street, where the Yaowarat neon threw red over the steam drifting up from a wok two stalls away.

"Because when it's done right," she said, "service makes people feel less alone without embarrassing them about it."

He didn't answer immediately because he was too busy registering the accuracy.

She went on, quieter now. "And because I grew up in a kitchen where feeding people was how love behaved when it didn't have the right words. So maybe I trusted it before I understood it."

Luca looked at her hands where they rested on the edge of the table — capable hands, marked by work in the ordinary ways that mattered. The street noise kept moving around them like weather.

"Yes," he said.

Nothing else would have been sufficient.

By the time they stood, the street had thinned from crush to flow.

Yaowarat at three in the morning was still fully itself, but the edge had come off the rush. More stools stacked. More shutters halfway down. The neon remained, because neon believes in endurance. Arno and the others were long gone. The woman with silver at her temples had begun dismantling part of the station without ever making the table feel unwelcome.

Luca paid for the bowls before Sofia could reach for her bag.

She noticed, of course.

"That was fast," she said.

"I had an angle."

"Very dishonest of you."

"Extremely."

She shook her head with the look of someone filing that detail where it might matter later.

They stepped away from the stall and neither reached immediately for the practical goodnight. The night had gone too far for that. Or perhaps not far enough.

"Walk?" he asked.

She answered without hesitation. "Yes."

They took the road west toward the river, the city opening in pockets as Chinatown gave way to quieter stretches. Shuttered storefronts. A cat threading under a parked scooter. The occasional all-night tea shop still lit. Their pace found itself quickly, side by side, close enough that their shoulders almost aligned and then did.

Bangkok at that hour felt less like a city asleep than a city speaking lower.

They talked still, but the conversation had changed register. Less inventory now. More drift. Homesickness came into it because it had to.

He told her he missed Europe in textures rather than monuments — the cold handle of a Paris door at six in the morning, olive oil in Amalfi that tasted almost green enough to chew, the exact sound of rain under Waterloo Bridge. She said she missed her avó's kitchen in São Paulo most in the half

hour before lunch, when everything had started to smell finished but nothing had reached the table yet. The waiting part. The promise before the meal declared itself.

"Tokyo made me lonelier than I expected," Luca admitted, watching the pavement ahead. "Not because people were unkind. Almost the opposite. Everything worked. It was just..."

"So precise there was nowhere to leak," Sofia said.

He looked at her. "Exactly."

"Bangkok leaks everywhere," she said.

He smiled. "It does."

They reached a riverside opening where the Chao Phraya lay black and broad under the scattered hotel light. A working boat moved south, leaving a wake that arrived in soft delayed folds against the bank. The air was marginally cooler here. He wondered if this was where they had passed each other without knowing. He almost said so. Didn't.

They leaned against the rail. Close enough now that if either shifted an inch, the other would feel it.

He was aware of her hand before he looked at it — resting flat on the rail, fingers relaxed, palm down. His own hand was beside it, not touching. The distance between them was not dramatic. Which made it harder.

He thought, not for the first time in his life but with more consequence than usual, about how many things can be ruined by reaching too soon simply because the wanting feels clear from the inside.

He did not reach.

Beside him, Sofia's hand remained where it was for one beat, then two, then shifted just slightly — not away, exactly. Back to her own side of the rail. The kind of movement that could mean anything and therefore meant too much if read carelessly.

Almost allowed, he thought, with a calm sharpness that made him unexpectedly grateful. Earned territory remained earned territory.

They stayed there long enough for silence to become ease rather than test.

Then Sofia turned toward him fully.

"We should probably do something practical before this becomes one of those stories no one believes later," she said.

"Agreed."

He took out his phone. The screen light made both of them look younger and more tired and, somehow, more real.

"Give me your number," he said.

She recited it. He entered it carefully, then handed her the phone so she could call herself, which she did, her thumb quick and competent. His pocket buzzed at once.

She looked down at her own screen a second later and typed something there too.

"Now you have mine twice," she said.

"Efficient," he said.

"Finally."

He should have said goodnight first. Instead he said, "I'll text you tomorrow so there's documented proof this happened."

Her expression changed in a way he suspected he would remember accurately for years.

"Please do," she said. "Evidence would help."

He walked her to the point where their routes separated. There the city returned — brighter street, a motorbike idling at the curb, early vendors beginning the invisible work that would become morning in two hours. They stopped under a sign with two missing bulbs.

"Goodnight, Luca."

"Goodnight, Sofia."

She took three steps, then looked back once over her shoulder as if checking whether the night was keeping its own promise. He was still there. She gave the smallest nod and turned the corner.

Luca stood in the street for five more seconds before moving.

Then he went home through a Bangkok that had shifted shape without changing any of its surfaces at all.

He slept badly in the specific way people sleep after a night that has moved something structural by less than an inch and yet enough to change the load-bearing lines of the whole building.

Not because he regretted anything. Because his mind kept returning, with infuriating clarity, to isolated details: her saying *service makes people feel less alone without embarrassing them about it*; the exact look on her face when he mentioned systems and emptiness; the way she had noticed his notebook by the shape of his pocket; the laugh, first and still first, cutting through the Yaowarat noise and reordering an old memory into a present fact.

At eight-thirteen, sunlight already hard on the window, he gave up on pretending to sleep further. He showered. Made tea. Opened the notebook.

He wrote only one line.

Some people arrive twice: once as pattern, once as person.

He looked at it, dissatisfied with the poetry of it, crossed nothing out, and reached for his phone instead.

He had, because he was himself, taken a picture on the walk back from the river — not of her, obviously, and not of the group. Of the noodle stall just as the woman with silver at her temples had started stacking the red stools upside down on the table: the stockpot still steaming, the tarp above catching the last of the neon, the whole scene looking both improbable and utterly ordinary.

Evidence.

He sent the photo.

Evidence we didn't dream it.

He watched the message go.

Then he put the phone faceup on the table and, for once in his life, did nothing at all to optimize the waiting.

End of Chapter 6